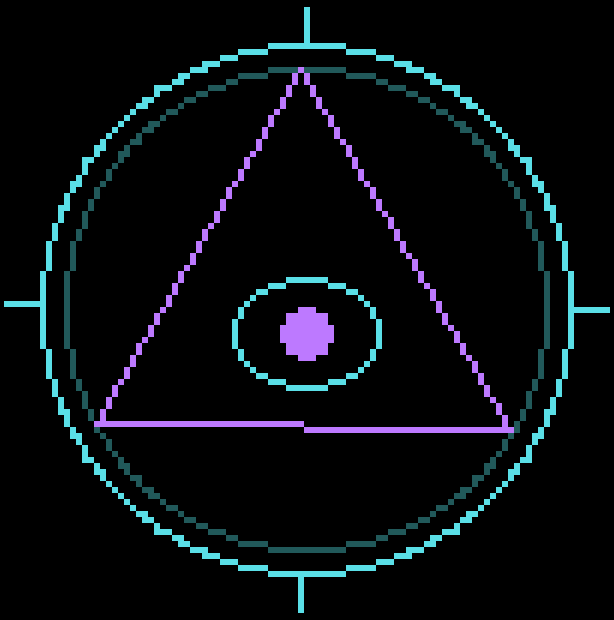


THE TITHE

THE DECK'S MANUAL, WITH NOTES

This copy: Mio Asagiri

For the Cardputer ADV

Version 0.6.0

QUICK START

If you're reading this, a Deck took to you, so congratulations, I think. I'm Mio, that's my name on the cover, and I found mine two months ago. The boxes are the manual that came with it and everything else is me talking. If the boxes and I ever disagree, go with the boxes.

WHAT YOU'RE DOING

Every WiFi router leaves an uncanny trace in the air, the current. Left unmoved, it goes stale, and people on that street feel it without knowing why. Fewer people can hear it every year, and the Deck is how you hear it. Most people who pick one up get hiss, which you won't. It only ever listens, and it never joins a network.

1. Every WiFi router in range is a well.
2. Draw energy from wells and offer it to wells that want it. Each offering makes Resonance, the ring a well gives when it gets what it was missing.
3. A Night is 12 visits, and a visit is one offering. Before they run out, make enough Resonance to pay the Tithe. Miss it and the Deck goes back to hiss until you bind a new week.
4. Seven Nights make a Binding, which is a week. Between Nights you spend coin at the Collector's stall, on relics and other things that make your offerings ring louder.

KEYS

; and .	Up and down
, and /	Left and right
ENTER	Choose
ESC	Back: the ` key, top left, or DEL, top right.

YOUR FIRST NIGHT

1. Put in a microSD card and turn the Deck on. It opens on BIND A NEW WEEK.
2. Keep WAYFARER (the starting setup) and CHALK (the easiest difficulty). Go down to BIND and press ENTER, then ENTER on THE CURRENT, and again on NIGHT 1.
3. The scanner is the Deck's main screen, and it lists the wells around you with the loudest at the top. Walk until one says IN REACH or NEAR. The * marks the best one.
4. Select it and press ENTER twice to visit.
5. Choose a DRAW line and hold the Deck still while it draws.
6. Choose OFFER. Press ENTER when the well stops ringing.
7. Walk to another well and do it again. Each offering uses 1 visit, and a well you've used settles in 20 minutes, after which you can use it again.
8. The bar at the top fills toward the Tithe. When it's full, the Night is paid.
9. Press ENTER for the Collector. Select the Caller on the first shelf and press ENTER to buy it;

it makes every well want your main energy more, for the rest of the week. ESC leaves, and Night 2 begins.

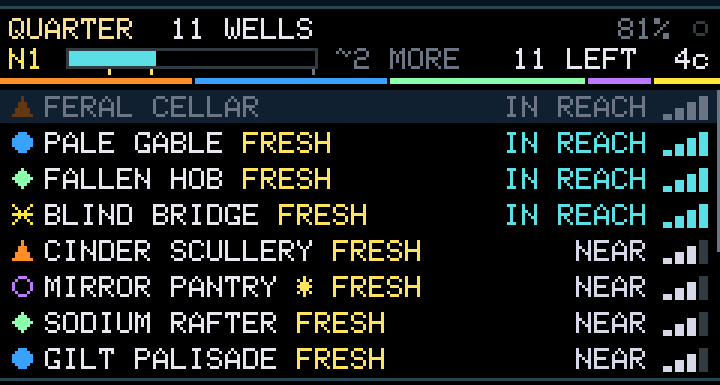
10. If you run out of visits before the Tithe, see OUT OF VISITS, page 24. Anything you've unlocked stays even if the Binding breaks.

Just take Wayfarer and Chalk your first time, and get clever later.

YOUR FIRST WEEK

My first Night took most of a Sunday, four hours and ten minutes and eleven visits. Yours will be slow too, because apparently everyone's is.

THE SCANNER



The loudest wells are at the top.

This is where you'll spend most of a Night. Reading from the top:

QUARTER 11 WELLS	Your ward (see WARDS) and the wells in range
BAR	Tonight's Resonance against the Tithe
~2 MORE	After your first offering: about how many more the Tithe needs. Red when that's more than you have left.
TICKS	Under the bar: where 6, 9 and 11 visits to spare land (see DAWN PAY)
N1	Night 1
11 LEFT	Visits left
4c	Coin

ICON	The well's energy (see ENERGIES). The yellow spark is Static, which pays well, but the Wardens notice (see HEAT).
*	The well where what you're holding, and your relics, pay most right now (see THE WORK, THE COLLECTOR)
IN REACH, NEAR	Close enough to use (see SIGNAL)
DIMMED	Used and still settling, or out of range
~~	A Hush well (see ENERGIES). Its name shows once you stand still.
FRESH	First heard in the last few scans
=	A namesake: a well with the same true name as one you've worked (see WELLS)
DIAMOND	A glyph you carved there (see GLYPHS). A hollow one in the header: a glyph adrift (see THE SCRYING GLASS).

On the harder Pacts, BONE and up (see PACTS), the Deck keeps the MORE count and the ticks to itself.

Follow the star for your first few Nights, then start arguing with it. On my street, ten wells is a loop past the pharmacy and back, about twenty minutes if I don't stop.

Mom works nights on the phone company's repair line, so most of the time there's nobody home to ask where I'm going. On her nights off she

thinks I've gotten really into walking, which I guess is true.

A VISIT

⌘ SUNKEN GUTTER HEDGE
STATIC WELL, IN REACH

⌘ DRAW STATIC
● DRAW TIDE (YOUR FOCUS)
⌘ OFFER 6 STATIC ~48
CAST A SPELL

TITHE 410 TO GO

ESC LEAVE ⌘6 6/8 12 LEFT 4c

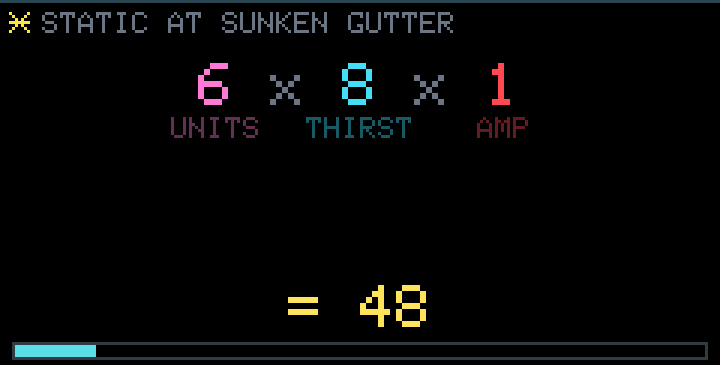
After a draw, OFFER appears.

1. DRAW takes the well's energy into your hold, the energy you carry with you. Stand closer for more.
2. You get one draw per well, and then the well needs 20 minutes to settle. Each Binding has a focus energy, Ember, Tide or Gale (see ENERGIES), and some wells offer it on a second DRAW line, with its symbol on their page. Choose one line.
3. Hold the Deck still while it draws, or some spills.
4. OFFER gives everything you hold of one energy to this well. Only offerings use visits; draws are free.
5. Some wells show FAVOR, a small job that pays as much coin as two to four offerings. It's worth saying yes at a well you're using anyway.

Keep your elbows in when you draw, because if you fidget it spills. I lost a quarter of a draw to a sneeze once. Also, if a well wants the same energy it just gave you, give it straight back, which took me two weeks to think of.

THE OFFERING

STATIC AT SUNKEN GUTTER



A first offering: 6 x 8 x 1.

Each offering makes Units x Thirst x Amp Resonance. The one in the picture is 6 units into a well with Thirst 8, at Amp 1, which makes 48.

UNITS	How much you offered
THIRST	How much the well wants that energy
AMP	Amplitude, or how loud it rings. It starts at 1, and relics from the Collector raise it.

The first time a well rang I said OH out loud, and a ninth grader on the stairs looked at me like I was a raccoon in a bin.

I say thank you to the well when it rings, not loud or anything. I tried not doing it once and it felt rude, so I went back to it.

DAWN

The Night ends the moment your Resonance reaches the Tithe, however many visits you have left. Dawn pays coin, and spare visits pay extra (see DAWN PAY).

THE COLLECTOR

1. The Collector's stall opens after every paid Night.
2. The * marks what would help you most, and says about how many fewer offerings a Night it saves. When polishing a relic you already hold beats anything on the shelf, the star sits on the YOURS tab (see POLISH). From BONE up (see PACTS) there's no star.
3. The first stall always stocks the Caller for your focus. It raises that energy's Thirst for the rest of the Binding.
4. ESC leaves, and the next Night begins.

Buy the Caller. After that first shelf the star's right about eighty percent of the time, which I know because I counted for two weeks.

THE SEVEN NIGHTS

1. The Tithe grows every Night.
2. Nights count visits, not hours, so a Night can take ten minutes or three days.
3. Nights 2 to 6 each bring an Omen, one rule for that Night (see OMENS).
4. Night 7 has an Eclipse, a harder rule. Night 1 names it (see THE ECLIPSE).
5. Running out of visits is normal early on, and the usual answer is a candle (one more visit, for coin), up to three a Night.
6. The Syndicate, one of the four factions (see FACTIONS), will lend you the rest of a Tithe, although it costs more than it looks (see OUT OF VISITS).

Most of my Nights are after school. Nights 3 to 6 are where Bindings break, and of the five times mine broke, four were on Night 3. So after the Caller I buy anything that multiplies, because the things that add feel nice at the stall and then don't get you through Night 3.

WHERE TO NEXT

That's enough to hold a week. The rest of this manual is for when the Deck shows you something you don't recognize. WORDS, at the back, has every term in one line, and IF SOMETHING'S WRONG is the page before it.

12 THE CURRENT What you're hearing
17 READING THE STREET Wards, energies
21 THE WORK Hold, Thirst, coin
23 THE NIGHTS Omens, Eclipse, visits
27 THE COLLECTOR Relics and wares
32 SPELLS AND GLYPHS Words and marks
35 FACTIONS Standing, favors, Heat
38 MOVING THE DECK Dowsing, the glass
41 WEEKS Callings, Pacts, unlocks
47 THE DECK ITSELF Keys, menu, saving
52 THE WALK LOG What it records
54 IF SOMETHING'S WRONG Surprises, fixes
56 WORDS Every term, one line each

THE CURRENT

Every router in the city says its name ten times a second, day and night, to anyone in range. Your phone hears the names and throws away everything else, which is a slow hum underneath the signal, left behind by every message and call that passes through the air. The people who can hear it call themselves listeners, and they call it the current.

You might have heard it already. Most listeners remember being the only one in the room who could hear the old television whine, or the fridge, or the lights at the swimming pool.

The Deck is how you hear the rest of it. It's a cheap pocket terminal with its radio set wrong on purpose, so it keeps what phones throw away. In most hands it plays hiss, but about one person in a few thousand picks one up and hears the current instead, and nobody knows why. This one took to you.

The current pools where signal is thick and runs thin where it isn't. Left alone too long, it goes stale, and you've probably walked through it already in the stairwell everyone hurries through, or the cafe where nobody stays, or on the block where your phone shows full bars and nothing loads. Listeners draw the current from the routers where it pools, carry it, and let it go where it's thin. When a well takes what it lacked, it rings, and that ring is Resonance.

When the work is done well, nobody walking past notices anything, except that the street feels a little easier to walk down.

A Deck goes stale like anything else unless current keeps running through it, and current only runs through it while you work. So listeners bind themselves to the current a week at a time, and each of the seven Nights of a Binding has a Tithe, which is enough Resonance to keep the Deck clear. Pay it and the Binding holds. Miss one and the Deck clogs, which is less terrible than it sounds, since other listeners keep the streets and your Deck only goes back to hiss until you bind again.

There used to be a listener every few blocks. Now there are fewer every year, and the streets go stale faster than anyone keeps them, so the city needs the few people who can hear it, and now that includes you.

WHERE I STARTED

This file gets copied from one Deck to the next along with everything else on it. Mine came with the manual and nothing else. The manual's never wrong, but whoever wrote it already knew all of it, and I didn't, and you probably don't either.

So these are my notes from my first two months, and I'm still at it. The list below is the first thing I ever wrote about the current, on my third day, and I'm leaving it in so you can see how little I knew.

DAY 3

1. It works. It actually hears something.
2. The something is called the current. I didn't name it. The name was already in the notebook on the Deck (it's called the Grimoire) in somebody else's handwriting.
3. There are wells everywhere and every one of them says its name ten times a second. My phone hears the names. The Deck hears everything else, and there's a lot of it.
4. Some people can hear it too. They're called listeners. The notebook says a Deck only works for about one person in a few thousand, and everyone else gets hiss.
5. So I'm one in a few thousand. I'm going to be weird about that for a while.
6. The current piles up in some places and goes stale. That's why

the stairwell by the gym feels like that. I KNEW it felt like that.

7. There used to be a lot more listeners than there are now.
8. You pull current out of a well, carry it, and give it to a well that doesn't have enough. That's an offering. When you get it right the well rings, and the ring is called Resonance. The Deck counts it for you, but I count it anyway.
9. Every Night for a week you owe a Tithe, which is enough Resonance to keep the Deck clear. Miss it and the Deck clogs up and goes back to hiss.
10. The notebook says nothing bad happens if you fail. You just stop hearing it until you start again.
11. I'm careful, so I don't think that'll be a problem.

update: failed on night 3. starting again.

That was two months ago, sixty-one days if you're counting, and I am. I've bound nine times since then, counting that one, and four of them held. I know every well on my block by its true name now.

I found my Deck on top of the e-waste bin behind the gym, the week the district collects old tablets. It looked like somebody had set it down there on purpose instead of throwing it away, and there was an old subway token taped to the back. I left it on my shelf for a week before I turned it on. I'm not sure what I was waiting for.

The first time it said EARS OPEN I was in the stairwell by the gym, and the whole stairwell went loud. That isn't a great word for it, but I haven't found a better one.

Before every draw I tap the back of the Deck twice and press it once with my thumb. It doesn't do anything. It's just my sister's trick for stuff that sticks. She moved out in March, and the last thing she did before she went was set my watch seven minutes fast so I'd never be late, "unlike some people." She calls on Sundays and asks if I've fixed it yet, and I haven't.

The only person at school who knows is Priya, and she doesn't believe me. She held it at lunch once and put it up to her ear like a shell and said it was just hiss. Then she handed it back really carefully, like it was broken and she didn't want to be the one who broke it.

READING THE STREET

I took the 14 downtown in my first week to hear what a lot of wells sound like.

My phone had full bars the whole way and nothing would load. The Deck counted 61 wells on one corner, and it sounded like a cafeteria with the doors shut.

Out past the river it's the opposite, maybe three wells, and every one of them pays like crazy.

There's a list of streets in the back of the Grimoire, in a few different people's handwriting, each with a date next to it. Most of them are crossed out. Calder isn't, and neither is ours.

The cafe on the corner of Calder closed in my sixth week and the block's felt heavier since, so I work it twice a Night now.

WELLS

1. A well is one WiFi access point. Several networks from the same router count as one well.
2. Every well has a true name, the same on every Deck, so two listeners can talk about the same one.

The well in the apartment over the pharmacy is called Feral Pantry, which is the ugliest name anything's ever been given, and I'm still not over it.

SIGNAL

IN REACH	Very close. The biggest draws. Some relics pay extra.
NEAR	Close enough to use.
FAR	In range, too far to use.
FAINT	Barely in range. Doesn't count toward the ward (see WARDS).
LOST	Missing from the last few scans.

Readings settle once you stand still.

Every well can be worked from somewhere public, so you never need to go inside anywhere.

WARDS

The number of wells in range sets your ward, and the ward changes what wells pay. Faint wells don't count, and the ward changes only once two scans in a row agree.

HOLLOW	0 to 3 wells. 15% fewer units, Thirst 40% higher.
FRINGE	4 to 10. Thirst 10% higher.
QUARTER	11 to 25. No change.
NEXUS	26 and up. 20% more units, Thirst 15% lower.

My bedroom is a Fringe with five wells, and three of them are the neighbors'. On a slow night I leave the Deck on the windowsill and do a round every twenty minutes, but outside is faster.

ENERGIES

A well's energy comes from its WiFi channel and its security.

- ▲ **EMBER** Busy low channels. Base Thirst 5.
- ● **TIDE** Middle channels. Base Thirst 5.
- ◆ **GALE** High channels. Base Thirst 5.
- ○ **HUSH** Hidden networks. Base Thirst 9. Never leaks from your hold (see HOLD AND THIRST).
- ✕ **STATIC** Open and guest networks. Base Thirst 8. Raises Heat (see HEAT).

Which wells offer your focus changes every Night.

Hush is my favorite. The wells that have it won't say their names, not even to phones, and it feels cold somehow, in a good way.

WHAT A WALK TURNS UP

1. Every well has a tune, played once as it comes into reach. A well you've offered at three times or more gets a longer note. M mutes it all.
2. After a few minutes' walking, stop and hold the Deck up for three seconds. It settles, and may show a scrap of talk from the street, or something found on the way, one line a stop. The Grimoire, the Deck's notebook, keeps them (GRIMOIRE > HEARD and GRIMOIRE > FOUND; see UNLOCKS AND THE GRIMOIRE).

3. FOUND means an odd kind of well, which goes in the field guide (GRIMOIRE > FOUND > WELLS).
4. NAMESAKE is a well somewhere else with the true name of one you've worked. The scanner marks it =.
5. A hollow diamond in the scanner's header is a glyph adrift, a mark you can keep (see THE SCRYING GLASS).

THE WORK

Most of a Night is walking. I stopped wearing headphones because I think you hear the current better with nothing in your ears, although I can't prove it.

The stairwell by the gym is fine now, and kids sit on it at lunch. Nobody noticed it change, which the notebook says is how you know it worked.

HOLD AND THIRST

1. Held energy slowly leaks away as you walk, except Hush, which never does. You carry up to 8 units in all; a Satchel (a Deck mod, see WARES) adds more.
2. Thirst depends on the energy, the well (each has favorites), the ward, and your standing with its faction (see FACTIONS).
3. In a Quarter or Nexus, a settled well that's already had an offering tonight wants less (Thirst x0.75), so a well at 8 drops to 6.
4. A well's own page shows its Thirst for what you're carrying, where you stand. Relics add to it when you offer.

I hoard Hush, because it's the only thing I can carry all Night without watching it shrink. Carrying two kinds at once has never once worked out for me.

Feral Pantry wanted Tide on Night 6 and paid 212 for it, so now I like the name about four percent more.

RESONANCE AND COIN

1. Resonance is what offerings make. It pays the Tithe and can't be spent on anything.
2. The coin you earn at dawn is what you spend at the Collector.

Coin is old tokens, the subway and arcade and laundromat and car wash kind that nothing takes anymore.

One morning in my first week there was a laundromat token in my coat pocket, and I'd never been inside a laundromat. The notebook says that after a good Night, tokens turn up by morning, in a pocket or a change tray or on the shelf under a well, and that nobody puts them there.

The subway token on the back of my Deck was taped on, though. So somebody puts those there, at least.

I keep mine in a sock. The dawn I had 25 saved up I counted them three times and didn't buy anything.

THE NIGHTS

The notebook says that on the seventh Night the Hum (that's all the current in the city at once) turns and looks at whoever's bound to it. I don't think it looks at anybody. I stood up straighter anyway, just in case.

The first time I got to Night 7 it was THE HUNGER. I paid it outside the pharmacy with one visit left, and then I sat on the curb for eleven minutes doing nothing at all.

OMENS

Nights 2 to 6 each bring an Omen, one rule for that Night only, shown in YOUR BUILD (press B). Except from BONE up (see PACTS), the stall shows the next one in its top corner, and the Tithe it names already counts it. The Diviner, a Calling you unlock later, sees two Nights ahead.

THE FADE	One energy is worth half
LOW TIDE	Units x0.75
SHORT NIGHT	2 fewer visits
SILENT BELL	Your first 2 visits make nothing
CROWDED SKY	Thirst x0.7 in Quarter and Nexus
EMPTY ROADS	Thirst x0.7 in Hollow and Fringe
STILL WATER	Relics that add Thirst give half
WARDENS WALK	You start at Heat 3
FOG	Relics see half the wells
BLOOD PRICE	The Tithe is 20% higher
TANGLED LINES	Relics multiply first, then add

THE ECLIPSE

Night 7 has an Eclipse instead, and Night 1 tells you which one.

THE SLEEPER	Polish (see POLISH) counts for half
THE HUNGER	The Tithe is 25% higher
THE DARK	2 fewer visits
THE DIMMING	Every xAmp gives a quarter less

You get a whole week to dread it. The week I got THE SLEEPER I'd put everything into Polish, which is exactly the thing it cuts in half. When it's THE DARK I start saving spare visits on Night 1.

OUT OF VISITS

When the visits run out before the Tithe, the Deck offers four ways out:

- LIGHT A CANDLE: one more visit, for coin, up to 3 a Night.
- TAKE THE SYNDICATE'S LOAN: pays the rest of the Tithe if you've already made 60% of it. Once a Binding, not on Night 7. The next Tithe grows by 1.25 times what they paid, and they keep that Night's offering coin.
- CAST HASTE: two more visits, if you hold the spell (see SPELLS).
- LET THE BINDING BREAK: end it here (see WHEN A BINDING BREAKS).

DAWN PAY

1. Dawn pays coin for each offering, each spare visit and, on the CHALK Pact (see PACTS), the Tithe. Coin

you're holding earns interest, 1 for every 5 held, up to 5.

2. Pay with 6 visits to spare and you get a Portent, which might be coin, a spell, a relic or a better stall. With 9 to spare you get two, and with 11 you get three. On the first three Pacts (CHALK, LEAD and IRON) each one comes as a choice of two; pick with up and down, and ENTER keeps it.
3. Pay with 1 visit or fewer to spare, or after a candle or a loan, and the Collector shows mercy, and the next stall adds a relic at half price, a free reroll and +1 Attunement (see WARES) on your focus.
4. Each dawn's coin comes with a token. Its kind depends on where you offered that Night; about one dawn in forty brings one NOT FROM HERE. GRIMOIRE > FOUND > TOKENS keeps them.

The notebook calls a Portent the current sending something back. The dawn I paid with eleven to spare I got three. THREE. I walked home the long way so it would last longer.

The kinder stall after a close Night is a rule, right there in the box, but it still feels like somebody being nice to me.

I took the loan once, on Night 5. I paid it off on Night 6 with my last visit, outside a dentist's office at ten at night.

WHEN A BINDING BREAKS

THE BINDING BREAKS

ON NIGHT 3

630 OF 900

EVERYTHING YOU'VE UNLOCKED STAYS

ENTER SEE WHAT IT EARNED

Unlocks are kept.

1. You lose that Binding and nothing else.
2. Everything you've unlocked stays, and the Binding still counts toward unlocks.

The notebook says the Hum doesn't hold grudges. I bound again the same night all five times.

THE COLLECTOR

The stuff on the Collector's shelf belonged to listeners who stopped. The notebook says the things you carry keep a bit of how you listened. I figure most of them just moved away, because that's what people mostly do.

THE STALL

THE COLLECTOR TITHE 900 24c
RELICS WARES YOURS 0/5 EMPTY ROADS

ATTUNEMENT	3c
ATTUNEMENT	3c
ATTUNEMENT	3c
MOD: EXTRA BREATH	10c

ATTUNEMENT
+1 Amp on one energy, for the rest of the week. You choose which.

ESC LEAVE ENTER BUY R REROLL 3c

The WARES tab.

1. The stall has three tabs, and left and right switch between them. RELICS are objects that change what an offering makes, and you keep them for the Binding. WARES is everything else it sells, and YOURS is the relics you hold.
2. R rerolls the relics for 3 coin, and each reroll after that at the same stall costs 2 more.
3. You can hold 5 relics, and X sells one back. Once all 5 are full, polish what you have (see POLISH).

The Collector says one thing at each dawn, and it's always about my Night, which is funny, because I've never told it anything.

The Collector shows up wherever you pay, and I've never seen it arrive. I tried once, in the 24-hour donut place on Calder. I stared at the Deck through the whole last ring without blinking, and the stall was just there.

Once it peeled the subway token off the back of my Deck and looked at it for a bit, then taped it back on and didn't charge me.

I've started saying prices the way it does. Mom asked how much the milk was and I said "Four," like that was a whole sentence.

WARES

- Attunement: +1 Amp on one energy for the rest of the Binding.
- Spells: each one works once. You hold up to 2 (see SPELLS), and with no room left you choose one to forget.
- Glyphs: a mark to carve into a well (see GLYPHS). You carry up to 4.
- Trinkets: coin and utility, in 2 slots of their own.
- Deck mods: upgrades to the Deck for the Binding.
- Faction relics: with good standing, a faction adds a relic to the shelf.

HOW RELICS FIRE

⌘ STATIC AT BLIND BRIDGE

6 × 11 × 18.4

UNITS THIRST AMP

LIT CLOSE CALL	+3 AMP
CLOSE CALL	+3 AMP
GRIDLOCK	x1.83 AMP

BEAT 48 AT SUNKEN GUTTER

= 1,216

1,216 / 900 ENTER LEAVE +2c AT DAWN

A Night 2 offering with four relics.

Amp starts at 1, and the first step of the offering count is ATTUNED, your Attunement on that energy (see WARES). Then relics fire in this order:

1. Relics that add Units or Thirst.
2. Relics that add to Amp.
3. Relics that multiply Amp.
4. Relics that make the offering count again.

Adding grows slowly and multiplying compounds, so +2 Amp on top of 1 makes 3, and x2 on top of that makes 6. (TANGLED LINES runs it the other way: x2 is 2, then +2 is 4.) Once an offering finishes, up and down scroll through every step, and ENTER leaves. ESC leaves at once, even mid-count.

If you only read one box in here, read that one. My best Binding was three relics that all wanted Hush in an empty place. On Night 6 one offering paid half the Tithe, under a

streetlight on a road with no houses on it.

HABITS

Every relic carries its last owner's habit, the way they listened. Relics with the same habit pay off on the same conditions, and the stall stocks more of the habits you carry.

THRONG	Busy wards, many wells
HOLLOW	Empty wards
FRINGE	The in-between, and changing wards
WAYFARING	Wells you've never visited
REFRAIN	Wells you visit again and again
ELEMENTAL	One energy, pushed hard
VARIETY	A mix of energies
SMUGGLING	Static, and Heat
HIDDEN	Hush and hidden networks
MACHINE	Channels, distance, mesh networks
TEMPO	When in the Night you offer
ECHO	Offerings that count twice, and copies
TOKENS	Coin
DECK	Stillness, sound, battery, dowsing
CURSED	Strong, with a drawback

POLISH

On the YOURS tab, ENTER polishes a relic. You can polish it three times, and each time makes it half again as strong.

SHINES

Some relics have a shine:

- GILT: 2 coin at the end of every Night.
- LIT: +3 Amp.
- PRISMATIC: x1.5 Amp.
- PHANTOM: takes no slot.

I've only ever seen one Phantom. I bought it with my last 10 coin and lost that Binding anyway, on Night 4.

SPELLS AND GLYPHS

In my third week I finally went into a laundromat, the one on Calder, because of the token.

There's a chalk mark on the tile by the door, right under the well above the change machine. You'd only see it if you were already looking at the well.

I didn't put it there, so somebody else does this, on my street.

SPELLS

SPELLS H

HASTE
+2 visits tonight

Run.

ESC BACK ENTER CAST

Type a name to jump to it.

Press C for the spell list.

GLAMOUR	This offering counts double
SURGE	Next draw: x2.5 units
TRANSMUTE	Your hold becomes your focus, and so do your draws for the next 4 offerings
HASTE	+2 visits tonight
ECHO	Offer to any well you've visited before, from anywhere
HEX	+8 coin
CHALK	Carve a random glyph into this well

The notebook says a spell is a bit of the current's music, kept like a sound in a bottle. I type the whole word every time, even when the list's already found it.

GLYPHS

A glyph changes what a well pays you for the rest of the Binding. Buy one on the WARES tab or cast CHALK, then carve it from the well's visit menu. A carved well shows a diamond on the scanner. Carving again replaces the glyph.

MINTED	+3 coin per offering there
RINGING	+4 Amp per offering there
ECHOING	Offerings there count twice
DEEP	+5 Units per offering there
BOUND	x1.5 Amp per offering there
BEACON	The well counts as new every time

Glyphs only pay where you go back, so the obvious first one is the well at home. I'm saving ours, so I haven't carved it yet.

FACTIONS

The Wardens took an offering from me in my fourth week.

I'd been giving Static all Night to any well that would take it. Then I gave a load of plain Ember to a well outside the Syndicate building on Fourth, and the number went up, and then it went to zero, and the screen said WARDENS TOOK IT and nothing else.

I know about Heat now, but I still don't know who was listening. The Warded say they've never sent anyone, and honestly I believe them.

THE FOUR FACTIONS

Listeners come in four factions, and each blames the stale streets on something different. A well's faction comes from its security.

THE HEDGE	Open and guest networks. Their energy is Static.
THE HEARTH	Home networks with a password. Most wells.
THE WARDED	WPA3 networks. They never take Static.
THE SYNDICATE	Business networks, and routers running three or more networks. They lend.

The notebook says the Hedge think the current belongs to whoever's standing in it, and that they mark brick with chalk.

The one at the laundromat is on tile, though, not brick.

STANDING

1. Offering at a faction's well raises your standing with it.
2. Offering Static lowers your standing with the Warded and the Syndicate.
3. High standing raises Thirst at that faction's wells, so they pay you more, and low standing lowers it.

FAVORS

1. Some wells ask a favor for the Night, like offering Tide at a Hearth well. Their page shows FAVOR; take it from the visit menu.
2. A favor pays coin and standing the moment you finish it. One favor is worth the coin of two to four offerings, so say yes at a well you're using anyway.
3. Some favors are deliveries, which add up over several offerings. YOUR BUILD shows how far along one is.
4. You can owe two favors, to different factions.

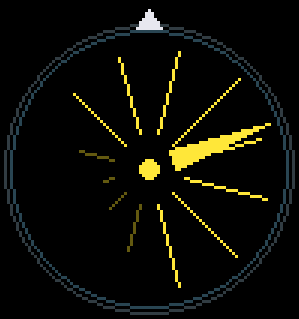
HEAT

1. Static offerings raise your Heat, and other offerings cool it. Press B to see it.
2. At Heat 2 an eye opens at the top of the scanner, with your Heat beside it. At Heat 3 it turns red and the Wardens listen: any offering may be taken, Static or not, for no Resonance and no coin.
3. TWIST hides you from them for a minute (see GESTURES AND STILLNESS).

MOVING THE DECK

My second week I dowsed in the grocery store parking lot at nine at night. You hold the Deck up and turn in a slow circle. A security guard watched me do four full circles and then got back in their car.

DOWSING



ASHEN SHRINE

RIGHT

69 DEG RIGHT

STRONG PULL

−60 dBm

ESC BACK ENTER AGAIN

The needle points to the loudest direction.

1. Open a well, press D, and turn slowly through a full circle.
2. Your body blocks signal from behind you, so the Deck can find where the well is loudest. A rising tone tracks the signal.
3. It works best outdoors, because walls reflect signal.

THE SCRYING GLASS

QUARTER
13

ASHEN SHRINE
IN REACH



ESC LIST ENTER OPEN 87%

Held still, Hush wells appear.

1. Press G. Wells float in a bowl, the loudest nearest the middle. Tilt the Deck and they drift.
2. A dowsed well sits at its real direction and turns as you turn.
3. Hush wells don't appear until you hold still. Once they do, they fade over a few seconds after you move, so you can pick one.
4. Some Nights, on a quiet street, a glyph drifts into the glass, and you'll see ADRIFT in the corner and a hollow diamond in the scanner's header. Hold still and it draws itself. ENTER keeps it (GRIMOIRE > FOUND > MARKS); a flick scatters it.

Sometimes a snap catches half a sentence out of the air, and usually it's somebody's mom, although once it was somebody counting.

On the bus I leave it on the glass. If you keep your hand flat on your knee long enough, the Hush wells come up like fish.

There's a woman at the 14 stop who sits really still at night with her phone flat on her knee, the way I do. She's probably just tired.

GESTURES AND STILLNESS

These only count while you hold the Deck up to look at it.

STILL	Hold steady a few seconds. Hush wells show their names, draws don't spill, and some relics pay more.
SNAP	Flick your wrist. The Deck rescans, and Hush wells show for 4 seconds. Sometimes you overhear something.
TWIST	Twist and back. The Wardens can't hear you for a minute. Once a Night.

The twist is a Hedge thing, according to the notebook. For a while I did it every time I passed the Syndicate building on Fourth, whether I was holding Static or not.

WEEKS

The day after I paid off the Syndicate's loan, a page in the Grimoire filled in, about the Syndicate. Somebody wrote it a long time ago, after doing the same thing I did.

I read the last line four times, and then I checked the Deck to make sure I didn't still owe anything. I stopped doing the twist outside the building on Fourth. To find out why, pay off a loan and read it yourself.

CALLINGS

BIND A NEW WEEK LISTENER

CALLING < WAYFARER >
PACT CHALK
BIND

No twist. The Deck as it comes.

< > CHOOSE ENTER BIND

, and / change the Calling or Pact.

A Calling is your starting setup, meaning the relics you begin with and sometimes a rule of its own. You choose it when you bind.

WAYFARER	The standard start
HEDGE WITCH	Two Static relics. The Wardens never come.
HERMIT	Built around wells you've visited before

PACTS

A Pact sets the difficulty. Each Pact adds to the ones before it, so IRON is LEAD's rule and its own.

CHALK	No change
LEAD	The Tithe pays no coin at dawn
IRON	11 visits a Night
ASH	Units x0.9
BONE	Some relics vanish 3 Nights after you buy them
SILVER	Rerolls start at 8, Polish costs double
OBSIDIAN	No loan, candles cost double
GOLD	One fewer relic slot

Pay all seven Tithes on a Pact to earn that Calling a seal in its material. The seal opens the next Pact for that Calling.

TRIALS

After your first held week, BIND A NEW WEEK gets a fourth row, TRIAL. A Trial is one rule for the whole week, in place of a Pact. Each held week opens the next. Lose a week on a Pact and BIND A NEW WEEK opens on the Trial that teaches what that Pact took, if it's open.

SHOESTRING	Never more than 15 coin
ONE NOTE	Your focus only, and the stall sells only Callers, Attunements and Polish
NIGHT OWL	8 visits a Night; Portents from 4 to spare

GLASS HOUSE	Start with Glass crown, which you can't sell. Tithes x2.5.
STATIC STORM	Every well is Static. Heat never cools.
THE LONG WAY	Wells you've visited before earn nothing
HOMEBODY	From Night 2, only wells you've visited before. They refill all Night.
EMPTY POCKETS	No stall. Each paid Night brings a relic and an Attunement.
GRAND TOUR	Visit all four wards each Night, or the Tithe doubles
REDLINE	Start with Overclock and Witching hour, and 2 extra visits. Tithes x2.5.

I have two seals, Chalk and Lead. Nobody's ever going to see them, and I check them anyway.

UNLOCKS AND THE GRIMOIRE

1. Most unlocks come from things you do in the world, like going downtown, finding Hush wells, dowsing, paying a Tithe on a nearly flat battery.
2. Unlocks are revealed when the Binding ends, two at a time. The rest wait for the next week.
3. A Grimoire page opens when you've done what its writer did. Read them in order and they tell you why the streets are going stale. Each page is also a theme, so

ENTER on an open page gives the Deck its colors.

4. Your rank rises with every Tithe you pay. Everyone starts as a LISTENER. BIND A NEW WEEK and the menu show it in the top corner, and YOUR BUILD shows the next one.

5. A locked relic, page or Calling says what opens it, and how close you are when it's something you get better at. A few say nothing at all.

6. Left and right in the Grimoire switch tabs: RELICS (every relic you've seen; HELD marks the ones you held a week with), RECORDS (your bests and where they happened), HEARD (every overheard fragment and Collector line you've caught), FOUND (what your walks turn up; see FOUND) and STREETS (the list of kept streets in the back).

7. STREETS opens with the Wells page. Walk the same stretch on three different Nights and the Deck asks A STREET YOU KEEP?; then STREETS offers ADD. Type your initials and a name (capitals, digits, space, hyphen and apostrophe), and it's written in under the others, in your own hand, dated by week. ENTER twice on one of yours crosses it out.

8. Pay all seven Tithes and the Deck offers OVERNIGHT: more Nights, each Tithe double the last, with Omens as before and an Eclipse every third Night. End the week whenever you like; it still counts as held.

THE TITHE WEEKS

9. Relics and coin stay with the week, and the Grimoire keeps the rest.

GRIMOIRE 1 PAGE 11/96 RELICS OPEN

THE FIRST DECK THEME

? ? ? ? ?
? ? ? ? ?
? ? ? ? ?
? ? ? ? ?
? ? ? ? ?
? ? ? ? ?
? ? ? ? ?

THEME: ASH

ESC BACK ENTER READ < > RELICS

Pages open one at a time.

FOUND

The Grimoire's FOUND tab keeps what your walks turn up. ENTER opens a section.

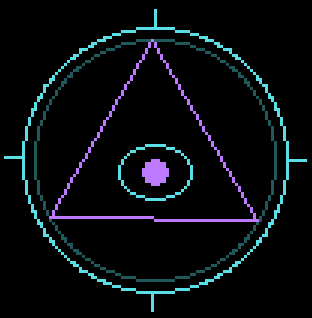
MARKS	Drifting glyphs you kept, as they were drawn
WELLS	A field guide: eight odd kinds of well, each filled in when you first meet one
NAMESAKES	Wells with the true name of one you've worked
WORDS	The words true names are made of, as you hear them
TOKENS	What came with each dawn's coin, by kind
WALKS	Your last seven walks as ribbons, in the colors of the wards you passed. A tick marks each offering.

I'm a WELLWRIGHT now. I told Priya and she said congratulations, carefully.

THE DECK ITSELF

SETUP

1. Put a microSD card in before you turn the Deck on. It holds a backup of your save and the walk logs.
2. Turn the Deck on. KEYS SEALED, GRIMOIRE SD OK, EARS OPEN and BALANCE TRUE mean it's ready.
3. NO CARD means there's no backup. Push the card in and press R.



All four lines lit means it's ready.

ALL KEYS

; and .	Up and down
, and /	Left and right. Scanner: the top or bottom of the list. Well page and glass: the previous or next well. YOUR BUILD, the stall and the Grimoire: the next tab. ATLAS: the order. BIND A NEW WEEK: the choice.
ENTER	Open, choose, buy. Glass: keep a settled glyph. The offering: leave once it's done. A Grimoire page: use its theme. The walk card: open the loudest well.
ESC	Back. Scanner: the menu. The stall: leave it, and the next Night begins. The offering: skip the count and leave.
DEL	ESC, except where you type: there it erases a letter first.
TAB	Tag your place for the walk log
G	The scrying glass, and back
S	The walk log, and back
B	YOUR BUILD: relics, spells and Heat
C	Cast a spell. Type its name to find it.
D	On a well: dowse
R	At the stall: reroll. Elsewhere: start or stop recording the walk.
X	YOURS tab: sell a relic
M	Sound on or off

TAB, R and M work on the scanner, the glass, a well, and the walk log.

THE MENU

DECK LISTENER

CONTINUE
YOUR BUILD
SPELLS
ATLAS
GRIMOIRE
THE CURRENT
WALK LOG
SOUND ON
GIVE UP THIS WEEK
●5 ○2 7/8 3 OF 8 WEEKS HELD

ESC BACK ENTER OPEN

ESC on the scanner.

CONTINUE	Back to the street
YOUR BUILD	Relics, spells, Heat, where tonight's Tithe comes from, and each Night of THE WEEK. Select any line to read what it does.
SPELLS	Cast one (see SPELLS)
ATLAS	Every well you've visited, with your best and total offerings there, your Nights there this week, what it likes most and the ward it was in. Left and right change the order, show only this week's wells, or sort by PAYS MOST: what each would pay now for your hold, the ~ number.
GRIMOIRE	Pages, relics, records, what you've heard and found, and the streets

THE CURRENT	The page you read when you first bound
WALK LOG	What the Deck is recording (see THE WALK LOG)
GIVE UP THIS WEEK	Ends the Binding. Asks twice.
BIND A NEW WEEK	When no week is bound
SOUND	On or off

Under the menu: what you're holding, and weeks held.

SAVING

1. The Deck saves as you go, so you can turn it off at any time.
2. A backup copy is kept on the card.
3. Switched off, the Deck still knows how long it was off (OFF FOR at boot) and lets wells settle meanwhile.

BATTERY AND SLEEP

1. When the Deck is set down or pocketed the screen dims, but in your hand it stays on.
2. On a dimmed screen the first key only wakes it, and so does picking the Deck up.
3. Face-down, the screen turns off and the Deck keeps listening.
4. After a walk with it pocketed, past wells it had never heard, take it out and hold it still. A card shows what you passed, with the NEW wells the Deck had never heard, the hidden ones, the wards, and the loudest well, which ENTER opens.

THE WALK LOG

My phone tells about forty companies where I am, and the Deck tells nobody, which I didn’t believe for about a month.

Priya asked once what I was recording, and when I said the street, she said everything records the street.

WALK 3 ● REC

TIME	12:00
WELLS	121, 10.1 NEW A MINUTE
SCANS	300
PLACE	STREET
FILE	W0003.CSV, 41 KB



HOLLOW 30% FRINGE 49%
QUARTER 21% NEXUS 0%

ESC BACK TAB PLACE R STOP 87%

A walk in progress.

While a card is in, the Deck logs every scan. The logs are used to check the Deck’s numbers against real streets.

1. Recording starts at power-on, and REC shows at the bottom of the screen.
2. Press TAB to tag where you are: home, street, transit, shop, work or park.
3. Spend at least 20 minutes in each kind of place you go.
4. Walk your usual routes on 3 or more days.

WHAT IT SAVES

1. On first boot the Deck creates a secret key and keeps it on the Deck.
2. Every network in a log is scrambled with that key, so the card alone can't be traced to real networks.
3. No network names or hardware addresses are ever saved.

Last week Priya asked if she could come along one Night. I said no, and then I said she could come as far as the pharmacy, because I needed toothpaste anyway. She asked to hold the Deck on the way, and it was still hiss, but she held it longer this time.

In week eight the chalk at the laundromat was gone. The tile around it was still dirty, so somebody had wiped off just the mark.

IF SOMETHING'S WRONG

WHAT JUST HAPPENED?

MADE NOTHING	The screen said WARDENS TOOK IT (see HEAT), or tonight's Omen is SILENT BELL.
NO OFFER	OFFER only shows once you're holding energy. Draw first.
CAN'T OFFER	The visit menu says why: too far, still settling, or Warded while you hold Static.
HOLD SHRANK	Held energy leaks over time. Hush never does.
WELL DIMMED	Used and settling for 20 minutes, or out of range.
NIGHT ENDED	You paid. A Night ends the moment Resonance reaches the Tithe.
STAR MOVED	The star follows what you're holding and where you are.
TITHE JUMPED	A loan from last Night, BLOOD PRICE, THE HUNGER, or a Trial.

TROUBLESHOOTING

NO WELLS	Wait a few seconds. The first scan takes about 2. Indoors with few networks, you may be in a Hollow.
NO CARD	Push the microSD card all the way in and press R.
KEY IGNORED	A dimmed screen uses the first key to wake. Press again.
SAVE LOST	A damaged save is set aside as deck.bad and the card copy loads. If both are gone, a new save starts.

WORDS

ADRIFT	A glyph in the glass. ENTER keeps it.
AMP	How loud an offering rings. Multiplies it.
ATTUNEMENT	+1 Amp on one energy for the Binding
BINDING	Seven Nights: a week
CALLER	A ware that raises your focus's Thirst for the Binding
CALLING	Your starting setup
CANDLE	One more visit, for coin. Up to 3 a Night.
COIN	What the Collector takes
COLLECTOR	The stall that opens after each paid Night
CURRENT	What routers leave in the air. The Deck hears it.
dBm	Signal strength. Nearer 0 is louder.
ECLIPSE	Night 7's harder rule
ENERGY	Ember, Tide, Gale, Hush or Static
FAVOR	A faction's task for the Night
FOCUS	This Binding's main energy
GLYPH	A mark carved into a well
GRIMOIRE	The notebook on the Deck
HABIT	What a relic pays off on
HEAT	How loud you are to the Wardens
HOLD	The energy you're carrying
INTEREST	Dawn coin for coin held: 1 per 5, up to 5

LISTENER	Someone who can hear the current
LOAN	The Syndicate pays the rest of a Tithe, at a price
MERCY	A kinder stall after a close Night (see DAWN PAY)
NAMESAKE	A well with the name of one you've worked
NIGHT	One round: 12 visits and a Tithe
NOT FROM HERE	A dawn token nobody recognizes
OFFER	Give energy to a well
OMEN	Tonight's one rule
OVERNIGHT	Nights past the seventh. Tithes double.
PACT	The difficulty
POLISH	Make a relic stronger
PORTENT	A gift for paying early
RANK	Your title, from Tithes paid
RARITY	Common, uncommon, rare or legendary
RELIC	Changes what offerings make
RESONANCE	What offerings make
SEAL	Proof you held a week on a Pact
SETTLE	A used well's 20 minutes
SHINE	A relic's extra
SPELL	One use. Type its name.
STALL	Where the Collector sells
STANDING	Where you stand with a faction
THEME	A Grimoire page's colors for the Deck
THIRST	How much a well wants an energy

TITHE	The Resonance a Night needs
TRIAL	One rule for a whole week, in place of a Pact
UNITS	How much energy you offered
VISIT	One offering at one well
WARD	Hollow, Fringe, Quarter or Nexus
WARDENS	They take offerings at Heat 3
WELL	One WiFi access point
WITHERED	A Bone relic that crumbles after 3 Nights
WK	Week: the date on your own streets

FOLDED SHUT

I folded the last two pages shut. There's a word on each fold. Don't open one until your Deck shows you that word. I mean it. You'll know.

FOLD 1: GO OVERNIGHT

FOLD 2: WELLWRIGHT

FOLD 1: GO OVERNIGHT

I said yes to it, once. Seven Nights paid, and the Deck asked if I wanted to keep going. Every Tithe doubles after that. I lasted three more.

I got home at two. Mom's shift runs until seven, so I wasn't being quiet. Her shoes were in the hall. She'd swapped her night. She was at the table with two cups out, and she didn't ask where I'd been. She asked if I'd eaten. I said yes, which was true in a broad sense.

The guy in 4B was on the stairs when I came in. He held the door and said "long one?" He has never said anything to me before.

FOLD 2: WELLWRIGHT

There's chalk on our well.

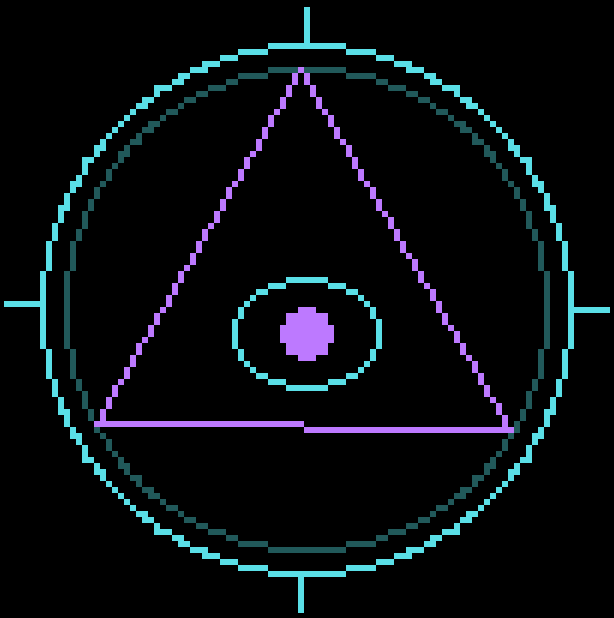
It's low on the wall, right under it, thirty-one centimeters from the floor. Same shape as the one on Calder.

The Deck has never told anyone where I live. I checked.

Mom says nobody's been in. Priya says it was probably always there.

I spent two months in front of that well deciding not to carve it.

It wasn't.



SEE YOU OUT THERE